

Standard Operating Procedure

Standardised Hand-Over Communication

«Hospital Name» — Supports AAC.10.d

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date	_____	Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» conducts and documents hand-over between shifts, between units, and during transfers — so no clinical information is lost when responsibility changes.

2. Scope

Applies to every doctor and nurse providing direct patient care, at every shift change, unit change, or transfer.

3. Responsibility

Outgoing Staff: gives a complete, documented hand-over before leaving.

Incoming Staff: acknowledges the hand-over and asks questions before taking over.

4. Procedure

1. Use the hospital's standardised hand-over framework (e.g. SBAR — Situation, Background, Assessment, Recommendation) for every hand-over, without exception. SBAR is recognised by the Institute for Healthcare Improvement, The Joint Commission, AHRQ, and WHO as an effective handoff communication tool — see Section 8, Reference 1.
2. Document the hand-over in the patient record — key clinical points, pending tasks, and any concern flagged during the shift.
3. The incoming clinician acknowledges the hand-over was received and understood, before the outgoing clinician leaves.
4. For a transfer between units or departments, the receiving team documents acknowledgement of takeover, not just receipt.
5. Never let a hand-over proceed undocumented or without acknowledgement — this is a CORE requirement with no exception.

5. Records

Supported by Records 6–7 of the AAC.10 Required Records pack.

6. Related Documents

- HCO_AAC_10_v2_REWRITE_DRAFT — AAC.10 policy

7. Review

Reviewed annually.

8. References

- Institute for Healthcare Improvement. (2017). SBAR toolkit: Situation-Background-Assessment-Recommendation. (Originally developed by Kaiser Permanente.) <https://www.ihl.org/library/tools/patient-safety-essentials-toolkit>